

OXFORD

INTERNATIONAL
AQA EXAMINATIONS

INTERNATIONAL AS LEVEL PSYCHOLOGY

(9685) Unit 2: Biopsychology, Development
and Research Methods 1

Report on the examination

June 2023

REPORT ON EXAMINATION: INTERNATIONAL AS LEVEL PSYCHOLOGY 9685 PS02 JUNE 2023

General Feedback

There were some very good performances within each of the topics in this examination. Some students demonstrated excellent psychological knowledge and understanding. Overall, students performed better on questions requiring AO1 and AO2 skills. However, some students are not engaging sufficiently enough with the research study scenario within the research methods questions.

Often, students did not achieve the same level of success on questions that required AO3 skills. For these questions, students tended to identify relevant evaluation issues but did not effectively elaborate upon these. This meant that evaluation was often limited, even if there were many different issues stated. Students should focus on giving elaborated evaluations when they are asked to provide information about strengths and limitations of particular sampling methods or experimental designs, for example.

Some students did not appear to have the specialist terminology required for sections of this paper. Other students used specialist terminology incorrectly, particularly within AO3 responses. This lack of appropriate terminology was particularly noticeable in the research methods section when it came to identifying designs used and sampling methods. As many students are working in their additional language, revising the psychological terminology listed within the specification is essential.

QUESTION 01

This question was answered correctly by most students.

QUESTION 02

There were some good responses to this question. Most students understood what neurotransmitters are, and the process of synaptic transmission. However, some students did not focus on the function of neurotransmitters, as mentioned in the question. These students tended to describe synaptic transmission without identifying the function of neurotransmitters within that process. Most could identify that neurotransmitters transmit information from one location to another. The students who obtained the highest marks often gave accurate and detailed responses with excellent use of specialist terminology, such as references to excitation and inhibition.

QUESTION 03

Most students achieved 2 or more marks on this question. Descriptions of the function of a relay neuron were generally stronger than the structure. Students who correctly described the structure often progressed to achieve 4 marks with a simple explanation of the function. Less successful students gave a general description of structure and/or function that could apply to any neuron. Some wrote about axons (plural) which is inaccurate. Another common error was describing impulses as travelling in the wrong direction (motor towards sensory).

QUESTION 04

This was a relatively straightforward question, but fewer students achieved full marks than expected. Many repeated the information in the question saying that the area was responsible for processing auditory information. This could not gain credit without additional information. Lots of students knew the location of this area but it was not relevant for this question. Less successful students focused far too much on the speech areas in their responses. Successful students identified the type of information processed and elaborated with what this area allows us to do.

QUESTION 05

Most students made a good attempt at this question and over half of the cohort achieved 5 marks or more. This was one topic where the knowledge of specialist terminology was particularly pleasing.

Description of the fight or flight response was generally well detailed. The strongest responses were concise with information presented in a logical order. In these responses application was embedded throughout, with stages of the response being illustrated with relevant aspects of the scenario.

Less successful students produced confused or disjointed answers. Others only discussed the response in very general terms. For example, stating that there is an increase in blood flow without attributing this change to any biological process. Many included too much detail on the long-term effects of stress which was not particularly relevant to this question. Weaker answers simply repeated elements of the scenario without applying these links to their knowledge of fight or flight.

Some errors seen included misattributing effects to the wrong substances or pathway. Students need to be particularly careful not to muddle the metabolic effects of HPA with the effects of adrenaline/noradrenaline. Students also need to correct their understanding of why muscles shake during the response (increased blood flow/pressure).

QUESTION 06

Many students made good attempts at this question with almost half of the cohort achieving at least half marks or more.

Students were not penalised for muddling names of researchers in their responses, providing there was enough detail for the examiner to clearly identify the research being discussed.

Relatively detailed knowledge of research studies was evident in many responses. There were also many successful references to axonal sprouting and neurogenesis, and a good understanding of CIT. However, many responses neglected to include significant evaluation of the studies or processes of plasticity and functional recovery. Where evaluation was included, it tended to revolve around a list of points with very little elaboration or explanation.

Less successful responses tended to include irrelevant information on the ways that the brain can become damaged, or excessive detail on therapies (eg drugs, stem cells, transplants). Weaker responses neglected to use specialist terminology, used it incorrectly, or did not accurately explain terms used. Examples included confusing CIT with CBT, and misuse of the term ecological validity within evaluation.

Successful students were able to make a clear distinction between plasticity and functional recovery (whereas weaker responses blurred these together). They showed knowledge of both research studies and functional recovery mechanisms. The best responses were constructed by providing a description of a study and then following this with effective evaluation of that study. This was then linked back to what it meant for our understanding of plasticity and/or functional recovery.

QUESTION 07

A good proportion of students achieved full marks on this question. Most were able to link the concept of equilibration to accommodation and assimilation. The most successful responses included effective examples to illustrate the balance of these processes. The very best responses often included a reference to disequilibrium to produce a more complete explanation and recognised its importance in cognitive development. Where students achieved partial marks, this was mostly due to a failure to elaborate.

Less successful responses tended to simply use the terms they were trying to explain within their explanations (without clarifying them) or muddled them completely. A minority confused the entire concept with conservation, or the stages of cognitive development.

QUESTION 08

A small number of students lacked knowledge of theory of mind, but of those who did recognise the concept most managed to access level 2 or above.

Despite being purely an application question, evidence of knowledge of the concept was enough to gain some limited credit. However, rather than beginning with a definition of the concept, better responses contextualised it within the scenario. Most students clearly understand the concept of theory of mind and the age at which it is thought to develop. In terms of application, the strongest responses featured references to both Robyn's and Mimi's understanding of what happened. The best responses included additional effective use of specialist terminology such as 'false-belief' and 'egocentrism'.

Weaker students simply defined theory of mind and followed this with common sense commentary using the scenario. For example, explaining that Robyn was surprised the ball was not in the box because she did not see it being moved.

Some students lost focus on the command words within the question and included lengthy descriptions of studies and findings into theory of mind. A small number of students muddled the names of the characters throughout their answers making their response very unclear.

QUESTION 09

A good number of students were able to access level 4 or above on this question, with almost all students attempting this essay.

Knowledge of scaffolding was good, and the zone of proximal development (ZPD) was well described by most students. For application, the strongest examples discussed the different scaffolding strategies that could be employed to help Arno cross his ZPD.

Less successful responses muddled Vygotsky with Piaget or confined their responses to scaffolding and ZPD with no further information included. Better responses featured a fuller explanation of the theory, including references to the role of language in thought and development.

Many students attempted evaluation through comparison with Piaget which was pleasing to see. However, it often lacked the explanation and/or elaboration required for greater credit. As in question 6, evaluation tended to consist of many different points with little detail or explanation of the arguments. This meant the evaluation gained limited credit. There was also misuse of terminology such as

reductionism within evaluation. The best responses featured fewer evaluation points, but these were detailed and well explained.

QUESTION 10

Whilst the majority of students got full marks on this question, some appeared to struggle more than expected. A sizable number simply did not attempt the question or did not achieve any marks.

There was some blurring between unstructured and semi-structured interviews. Some students clearly lacked the terminology despite being able to describe the correct idea.

The best responses referenced both the teacher and the students to make the application requirement very clear. Less successful students simply defined what is meant by an unstructured/semi-structured interview, failing to relate their answer to the context of the scenario.

QUESTION 11

Most students correctly answered this question.

QUESTION 12

This question was more strongly applied than some of the other research methods AO2 questions. Weaker responses did not explicitly make the connection between a sample bias and the resulting sample being unrepresentative. Less successful responses missed the focus on sampling. Instead they tended to include references to demand characteristics, or investigator effects during the interviews.

Students must read questions carefully to avoid including irrelevant information. In this question plenty of students focused on how to avoid sampling bias rather than explaining why there was one.

QUESTION 13

Many students answered this question in the context of the scenario. Whilst this was not required, these responses could still access all the available marks. References to demand characteristics were not creditworthy for this question. For 'time consuming' to gain full credit, references to the construction of questionnaires and the delivery of interviews were required. Generic statements regarding expense or time gained little credit.

There were some good responses which centred around the understanding of the questions, or verbalising thoughts and opinions. In addition, some better responses featured the difficulty in analysing subjective data. The strongest responses ensured that their responses were not focused on a single method of self-report, as those that applied only to interviews or questionnaires were less effective.

Very few students achieved all 4 marks on this question. A key issue was a lack or misuse of specialist terminology. This resulted in vague descriptions of social desirability bias or subjective data that could

not be classed as clear explanations. The weakest responses featured poor explanations of the impact of interviewers on the responses of interviewees.

QUESTION 14

Around half of the students achieved full marks on this question. The most common response was reference to first-hand data collection. The strongest responses then provided a clear explanation of why the data was first-hand in the context of this study.

Again, students need to read the question carefully to avoid including irrelevant information as some provided descriptions of the benefits of primary data, which was not required by this question.

QUESTION 15

Many students did not get any marks on this question, and it was one of the most poorly answered questions on the paper. This was largely down to inclusion of measures taken before or after the interview rather than during. Additionally, there was evidence of some misunderstanding around the difference between consent and debrief (although neither is relevant).

Less successful students referred to environmental aspects, or 'not judging' the participants based on their responses. Similarly, not asking questions that cause anxiety or references to the mannerisms of the interviewer were not creditworthy here.

More successful students were able to focus in on the 'during' aspect of the question. They provided appropriate suggestions (commonly right to withdraw and confidentiality) without references to consent, debriefing or before/after the interview.

QUESTION 16

Just under half of the students achieved full marks on this question. Statements regarding the aim were regularly included effectively. This was the easiest aspect to apply clearly to this scenario.

As in question 15, there was some confusion evident regarding the difference between consent and debrief. If the response explicitly stated that participants were given the information before they were interviewed it could not gain credit. Otherwise, benefit of the doubt was given.

Given the large amount of information that should be shared in a debrief, many responses were rather short. Some only referred to addressing deception which was not particularly relevant to this context. Many weaker responses listed the elements of a debrief with no application. The better responses included reference to several elements of a debrief, each clearly in the context of the scenario.

QUESTION 17

This question was not answered well by most students. Some muddled up the data types. A common issue was responses not being comparative, just describing the two data types separately. Generic responses about ease of comparison or collection were not given credit without elaboration. References to time or expense were also not creditworthy.

Some students appeared to have the misconception that opinions and beliefs can only be studied using qualitative data.

In terms of analysis, students needed to be clear that further processing was required for qualitative data to be analysed statistically (but not for quantitative). Some said that qualitative data cannot be analysed graphically or statistically which is inaccurate.

When making comparative statements, students must ensure that these are in relation to the same idea. Successful students produced simple comparative statements regarding the nature of the data and the richness of detail or subjectivity.

QUESTION 18

Performance on this question was surprisingly poor. Students often misidentified the design (most as matched pairs) or referred to types of experiment instead. There was evidence of a lack of terminology when identifying the design.

QUESTION 19

Just over half of the students were able to gain at least 1 mark for this question. Many neglected to fully operationalise the dependent variable by stating that the score was out of 20. Where students did not achieve any marks, this tended to be due to misidentification of the independent variable as the dependent variable. Some students also wrote irrelevant statements about the aim or expected results of the study.

QUESTION 20

This question was often not attempted and was the most poorly answered question on the paper. Once again, there was some issue regarding terminology with several students identifying the type of experiment as natural or naturalistic. If students did this, there was benefit of the doubt given for the justification (classroom setting). There was a small number who wrote about experimental designs rather than types of experiment or made references to observations.

Successful students were able to give a clear justification in the context of the scenario, whilst weaker responses had no application of knowledge to the scenario, and merely defined what a field experiment is.

QUESTION 21

This question was also poorly answered or not attempted.

Many students made the connection between individual differences and matched pairs design as a method of control. Where IQ was given as the difference the link needed to be made between IQ testing and matching participants for full credit. Some students struggled to achieve marks because they made use of generic individual differences or environmental variables without application.

A more commonly missed element within responses was the command in the question of 'how the teacher could have dealt' with the issue identified.

There were some good responses which were based on time spent revising and the teacher giving time limits or monitoring revision in class. Where the suggested method for dealing with the issue featured the teacher giving instructions to the students, credit was given. The students in the scenario may not have followed these instructions but benefit of the doubt was given.

GET HELP AND SUPPORT

Visit our website for information, guidance, support and resources at oxfordaqaexams.org.uk

FAIR ASSESSMENT PROMISE

In line with OxfordAQA's Fair Assessment promise, the assessment design, marking and awarding of this examination focused on performance in the subject, rather than English language ability.



OXFORD INTERNATIONAL AQA EXAMINATIONS
GREAT CLARENDON STREET, OXFORD, OX2 6DP
UNITED KINGDOM

info@oxfordaqaexams.org.uk
oxfordaqaexams.org.uk

Permission to reproduce all copyright material has been applied for. In some cases, efforts to contact copyright-holders may have been unsuccessful and Oxford International AQA Examinations will be happy to rectify any omissions of acknowledgements. If you have any queries please contact the Copyright Team, AQA, Stag Hill House, Guildford, GU2 7XJ.